You can't just wish that kind of depression away. You get your head down and get on with what you know you've got to do. United players are lucky that the manager understands his players well enough to recognize how they're feeling and that they're not faking it. Maybe because of that, pre-season wasn't as hard as it's sometimes been in the past. Even so, when we kicked off 2002/03 I still felt a long way off ready for a new season which, after the previous May had come and gone without a trophy at Old Trafford, had plenty riding on it. When you don't feel right, sometimes you need to work that much harder, to train and play your way through it, and I was ready for that. What I didn't realize was that some of the worst of what lay ahead had nothing to do with soccer at all.

Victoria and I do what we can to keep our lives organized; not just to keep our own heads straight but because our schedules mean life's already complicated enough for Brooklyn and Romeo. Sometimes, though, things come out of nowhere, things you could never lay plans for. And, even if you could, you wouldn't want to because just thinking about them would have you wanting to lock your front door and never come out.

The first game in November at Old Trafford was against Southampton. Not a game that, usually, would have stuck in my mind. We weren't at our best and it was one of those afternoons when you're glad to have done enough to take all three points. For all that every home game is a big occasion, especially when you're wearing the captain's armband like I was with Roy Keane out injured, I came off at the end of our 2–1 win with a bit of a 'that's another Saturday afternoon' feeling. I was looking forward to seeing Victoria and heading home for a night in with the boys. Which meant that what was waiting for me came as all the more of a shock.

As soon as I got to the dressing room, the manager said we needed to talk in his office. Not after I'd changed. Not as soon as I could. Now. So I clattered through, still in my boots and my uniform. We went inside. I don't know what I was expecting but it wasn't that Victoria would be there waiting for us. She looked pale and nervous. *I'm handling this but only just*. I looked at her, as if I expected her to tell me what was going on: it's such a strange feeling, knowing something's terribly wrong, just from the tension in the room, but not having any idea what it was. I looked at the manager, too. He looked drawn. It was only then, really, that I took in the other people who were present: four of them. One I half-recognized as a Manchester-based police officer and he introduced me to the other three. They were from SO7, the Serious and Organized Crime Command unit, and had driven up from Scotland Yard.